PROGRAM

2026 International Symposium for Plant Vascular Pathosystems (ISPVP)

October 20th-23rd

South Padre Island, Texas, USA

Theme: Confronting Endemic and Emerging Plant Vascular Pathogens, Insect Vectors, and Diseases Together.

Venue

Holiday Inn Resort South Padre Island

100 Padre Blvd

South Padre Island, TX 78597

Sponsors

TEXAS A&M AGRILIFE RESEARCH AND EXTENSION CENTER AT WESLACO

TEXAS A&M UNIVERSITY Plant Pathology & Microbiology

RAFT CITRUS RESEARCH AND FIELD TRIAL FOUNDATION, INC.

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Southwest University, China

Keynote Speakers



Dr. Gitta Coaker
Professor
University of California, Davis

Professor Gitta Coaker is the John and Joan Fiddyment Endowed Chair in Agriculture at the University of California, Davis, where she has been a faculty member since 2007. Her research focuses on innate immune perception and the spatial regulation of plant defense, with an emphasis on immune receptor activation and engineering. Her work also examines host targets of vascular pathogens, including vector-borne diseases associated with *Liberibacter* species.

Dr. Coaker is an American Association for the Advancement of Science Fellow (2026). She has received several awards, including the William H. Krauss Award for Research Excellence (2004), the NSF CAREER Award (2011), the Chancellor's Fellow for Research Excellence (2013), the Graduate Student Mentoring Award at UC Davis (2020), and the Noel T. Keen Award for Research Excellence in Molecular Plant Pathology (2022).



Dr. Leonardo De La Fuente
Professor
Auburn University

Leonardo De La Fuente earned his B.S. in Biochemistry and M.S. in Microbiology from the University of the Republic in Montevideo, Uruguay, and began his research career at the *Instituto de Investigaciones Biológicas Clemente Estable* (IIBCE). He moved to the United States in 2001 to pursue a Ph.D. in Plant Pathology at Washington State University, followed by a postdoctoral appointment at Cornell University's New York State Agricultural Experiment Station from 2005 to 2008. In 2008, he joined the Department of Entomology and Plant Pathology at Auburn University (Alabama), where he has served as a full Professor since 2019. His research and teaching focus on plant-associated bacteria, and he has published more than 100 peer-reviewed articles. Over the past decade, his work has focused on understanding the epidemic caused by the bacterial pathogen *Xylella fastidiosa* in Europe. Leonardo has contributed to the development of European Union regulations as an external expert for multiple European Food Safety Authority (EFSA) opinions. He is currently Editor-in-Chief of *Phytopathology*, having served on the journal's editorial board for more than 11 years.

Tuesday, October 20- Arrival and Registration/ Check-In

Time	Speaker	Title
5:00–7:00 PM	Registration/Check-in	Registration/Check-in/Upload PowerPoint presentations/Poster Setup (**Lobby**)

Wednesday, October 21- Sessions 1 and 2

Time	Speaker	Title
7:00–8:30 AM	Breakfast	Breakfast (**Hibiscus Room- Left Side**)
7:30-8:30 AM	Registration/Check-in	Registration/Check-in/Upload PowerPoint presentations/Poster Setup **(Hibiscus room)**
8:45–9:00 AM	Opening Remarks	**Kranthi Mandadi, Texas A&M University** and **Nian Wang, University of Florida.** ***Email: kranthi.mandadi@ag.tamu.edu*** ***Email: nianwang@ufl.edu***
9:00–10:00 AM	Keynote Speaker	**Leo De La Fuente, University of Auburn-** Adaptive strategies of a xylem-limited bacterium for survival in the plant vascular system (45–50 min presentation + 10–15 min questions) ***Email: lzd0005@auburn.edu***
10:00-10:15 AM	Break	Coffee break
10:15–10:20 AM	Session 1 Introduction	**Judith K. Brown, University of Arizona** (Vector Biology, Epidemiology, and Diagnostics) ***Email: jbrown@ag.arizona.edu***
10:20–11:05 AM	Invited Speaker	**Judith K. Brown, University of Arizona** — *Multiomics* interrogation of psyllid vector–*Ca*. *Liberibacter* interactions in divergent co-evolved *pathosystems* (30–35 min presentation + 5–10 min questions) ***Email: jbrown@ag.arizona.edu***
11:05–11:45 AM	Oral Presentation	**Alisson da Silva Santana, Texas A&M University** — Spatial Distribution of the Corn Leafhopper (*Dalbulus maidis*) within Corn Fields in South Texas (30–35 min presentation + 5–10 min questions) ***Email: alisson.santana@ag.tamu.edu***
11:45–12:10 AM	Oral Presentation	**Surender Kumar, Texas A&M University** — Development of a Cas13a-based Rapid, Grower-Friendly Detection Tool for Tomato Spotted Wilt Virus (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: surender.kumar@ag.tamu.edu***
12:10–1:15 PM	Lunch	Lunch provided — (**Hibiscus Room- Left Side**)
1:15–1:20 PM	Session 2 Introduction	**Baoye He, Texas A&M University** (Molecular Host–Pathogen Interactions and Biotechnology) ***Email: baoye.he@ag.tamu.edu***
1:20–2:00 PM	Invited Speaker	**Baoye He, Texas A&M University** — Extracellular Vesicles as a Root-To-Shoot Communication System Triggered by Root Microbiota (30–35 min presentation + 5–10 min questions) ***Email: baoye.he@ag.tamu.edu***
2:00–2:40 PM	Oral Presentation	***Pankaj Kumar Yadav****, **Texas A&M University** — Fungal sRNAs Target Plant Mitochondria to Suppress Host Immunity (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: pankaj_1263@tamu.edu***
2:40–3:05 PM	Oral Presentation	**Maryam Khalilzadeh, University of Florida** — Role of the Membrane Contact Site Protein SYNAPTOTAGMIN A During *Candidatus Liberibacter* asiaticus Phloem Infection (20 min presentation + 5 min questions)

*Student**

		Email: mkhalilzadeh@ufl.edu
3:05–3:20 PM	Break	Coffee break
3:20–3:45 PM	Invited Speaker	***Chi-Kuan Tu**, Texas A&M University* — A Multiplex CRISPR-based genome editing strategy to identify citrus immune regulators that confer resistance to HLB disease (30–35 min presentation + 5–10 min questions) ***Email: cktu@ag.tamu.edu***
3:45–4:10 PM	Oral Presentation	**Manikandan Ramasamy, Texas A&M University** — Hairy Root Platform Enables Antimicrobial Discovery Against Fastidious *Candidatus Liberibacter* species and Field Validation in HLB-Affected Citrus (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: mani.ramasamy@ag.tamu.edu***
4:10–4:30 PM	Poster Presentation	Poster presentation (**Hibiscus Room- Right Side**)
4:30–6:30 PM	Opening Banquet Dinner	Dinner + drink tickets (**Hibiscus Room- Left Side)**

Thursday, October 22- Sessions 3 and 4

Time	Format	Program
7:00–8:30 AM	Breakfast	Breakfast (**Hibiscus Room- Left Side**)
7:30-8:30 AM	Registration/Check-in	Registration/Check-in/Upload PowerPoint presentations/Poster Setup **(Lobby/Hibiscus room- Right Side)**
8:45–9:00 AM	Transition/Introduction	**Kranthi Mandadi, Texas A&M University** (**Hibiscus room- Right Side**) ***Email: kranthi.mandadi@ag.tamu.edu***
9:00–10:00 AM	Keynote Speaker	**Gitta Coaker** — Spatial and Structural Strategies of Xylem- and Phloem-Colonizing Bacterial Pathogens (45–50 min presentation + 10–15 min questions) ***Email: gloaker@ucdavis.edu***
10:00-10:15 AM	Break	Coffee break
10:15–10:20 AM	Session 3 introduction	**Nian Wang, University of Florida** (Pathogenesis, Plant Physiology, and Disease Tolerance) ***Email: nianwang@ufl.edu***
10:20–11:00 AM	Invited Speaker	**Nian Wang, University of Florida** — Mechanistic dissection of *Candidatus* Liberibacter Triggered Chronic Immune Disease (30–35 min presentation + 5–10 min questions) ***Email: nianwang@ufl.edu***
11:00–11:40 AM	Invited Speaker	**Amit Levy, University of Florida** — Fitting the Pieces into a Whole Picture: Physiology and Pathogenesis in Huanglongbing Disease (30–35 min presentation + 5–10 min questions) ***Email: amitlevy@ufl.edu***
11:40–12:05 AM	Oral Presentation	**Maryam Khalilzadeh, University of Florida** — HLB tolerance is associated with maintained carbon export despite callose accumulation (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: mkhalilzadeh@ufl.edu***
12:05 AM–1:10 PM	Lunch	Lunch provided — (**Hibiscus Room- Left Side**)
1:10–1:15 PM	Session 4 Introduction	**Ute Albrecht, University of Florida** (Integrated Disease and Pest Management Strategies) ***Email: ualbrecht@ufl.edu***
1:15–1:55 PM	Invited Speaker	**Ute Albrecht, University of Florida** — Integrating different Horticultural Practices to manage endemic Huanglongbing (30–35 min presentation + 5–10 min questions) ***Email: ualbrecht@ufl.edu***
1:55–2:20 PM	Oral Presentation	**Chuanyu Yang, Texas A&M University** — Trunk Injection of Oxytetracycline for the Management of Citrus Huanglongbing and Its

		Effects on the Citrus Microbiome in South Texas (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: yangchuanyu@tamu.edu***
2:20–2:45 PM	Oral Presentation	**Flavia Campos Vieira, University of California** — Secondary metabolites of citrus-associated Bacillus spp. inhibitory to *C*Las and citrus root pathogens (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: flavia.camposfreitasvieira@ucr.edu***
2:45–3:00 PM	Break	Coffee break
3:00–3:25 PM	Oral Presentation	**Waqar Shafqat, University of Florida** — Optimization of Phenology-Based Oxytetracycline Trunk-Injection Timing to Suppress *C*Las Titer and Improve HLB-Affected Citrus Tree Health (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: waqar.shafqat@ufl.edu***
3:25–3:50 PM	Oral Presentation	***William Anderson****, **Texas A&M University***— Engineering ihpRNAi Constructs for RNAi-Mediated Resistance to Grapevine Leafroll-associated Virus 3 (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: wanderson15@tamu.edu***
3:50–4:15 PM	Oral Presentation	***Jacobo Robledo****, **University of Florida*** — Predicting tree-level yield in an endemic vascular pathosystem under HLB (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: Jacobrobledobur@ufl.edu***
4:15–4:40 PM	Oral Presentation	**Jawwad Qureshi, University of Florida** — Citrus tree protection and production against the citrus pest complex (20 min presentation + 5 min questions) ***Email: jawwadq@ufl.edu***
4:40–5:30 PM	Networking/Break	Networking and connection among participants; discussion of future collaborations
5:30–7:00 PM	Closing Banquet/Dinner	Dinner + drink tickets / Dinner / Drink tickets / **Sea4Ever, 5th Floor)**

Friday, October 23th, 2023 (Room: Bastrop, 3rd floor, Tower A)

Time	Format	Program
7:00–8:30 AM	Breakfast	Breakfast — (**Hibiscus Room- Left Side**)
8:30 AM–Noon	Networking & Local Activities (On your own)	Participants are welcome to explore local tours, network, or arrange personal activities
Noon	**Close**	**Conference closes by noon; departures**

*Student**

POSTER SUBMISSIONS

Presenter	Title
Carmen Padilla, **Texas A&M University**	Spinach-Derived Antimicrobial Peptides as a Novel Strategy for Tolerance to Citrus Greening and Potato Zebra Chip Diseases. *Email: carmen.padillamarcia@ag.tamu.edu*
Ashley Zavala*, **Texas A&M University**	Changes In Vector Feeding Behavior Arising from Application of Heat are Detectable Using Signal Analysis Techniques *Email: azavalae01@tamu.edu*
Qiuni Yang*, **Texas A&M University**	Investigating Pierce's Disease (*Xylellea fastidiosa*) Tolerance and Resistance in Historical Grapevine (*Vitis* spp.) Cultivars Developed by T. V. Munson *Email: qiuni2326@tamu.edu*
Damodar Pokhrel*, **Texas A&M University**	Evaluation of trunk-infusion volume and site of application on the uptake of oxytetracycline (OTC) by HLB affected grapefruit (*Citrus × paradisi*) trees *Email: Damodar.pokhrel@students.tamuk.edu*
Nancy Her*, **University of California**	Lipopolysaccharide structure influences the biogenesis and cargo selection of *Xylella fastidiosa* outer membrane vesicles *Email: nher002@ucr.edu*
Mia Acker*, **University of Florida**	Complete genomes reveal metabolic differences between Lethal Bronzing Phytoplasma, co-recovered *Candidatus* Uzinura, and phloem-limited pathogens *Email: miaacker@ufl.edu*
Aditya Kulshreshtha, **Texas A&M University**	Hairy Root Transformation in *Citrus medica* L.: An Efficient Platform for HLB Therapeutics Discovery *Email: aditya.kulshreshtha@ag.tamu.edu*
Junseong Kang*, **Texas A&M University**	Development of a Viability qPCR Assay *Fusarium oxysprum f. sp. vasinfectum Race 4* *Email: junseong_kang@tamu.edu*

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